

Starting a Peer Support Group — Checklist

Phase 1: Foundation

- ☐ **Define your purpose.** What specific need does this group meet?
- ☐ **Choose a format.** In-person, virtual, or hybrid?
- ☐ **Set a schedule.** Weekly? Bi-weekly? Same time every session.
- ☐ **Identify your co-facilitator.** Never facilitate alone.
- ☐ **Draft group agreements.** Confidentiality, respect, attendance, participation.
- ☐ **Find a venue.** Quiet, private, accessible. Or pick a video platform.

Phase 2: Operations

- ☐ **Create an intake form.** Name, contact, what brings them, any accommodations needed.
- ☐ **Set a max group size.** 6–8 is the sweet spot for peer support.
- ☐ **Establish a waitlist process.** What happens when you're full?
- ☐ **Draft a confidentiality agreement.** Review it at the start of every session.
- ☐ **Decide on record-keeping.** Notes per session? Only if someone is at risk?
- ☐ **Set boundaries.** What happens between sessions? Can participants contact you directly?

Phase 3: Launch

- ☐ **Recruit your first members.** Start with people you already know.
- ☐ **Do a dry run.** Meet with your co-facilitator and walk through a session.
- ☐ **Prepare an opening script.** Welcome, introductions, group agreements, check-in format.
- ☐ **Prepare a closing ritual.** Summary, resources, next session date.
- ☐ **Send a pre-session email.** Date, time, location/ link, what to expect.

Phase 4: Sustain

- ☐ **Debrief after each session.** What worked? What didn't?
- ☐ **Track attendance.** Notice patterns and reach out if someone disappears.
- ☐ **Check in with your co-facilitator.** How are they doing? Do you need to adjust roles?
- ☐ **Review group agreements regularly.** Are they still serving the group?

- ☐ ****Plan for endings.**** What happens when a member leaves? When the group ends?
 - ☐ ****Evaluate every 6–8 sessions.**** Is the group still meeting its purpose?
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This checklist draws on guidelines from the International Association of Peer Support Facilitators and years of direct facilitation experience.
